didn’t make war against civilians: Soldiers fought soldiers. Then came World War II and Hitler’s philosophy of total war, which meant the bombing not only of soldiers but of factories that produced their rifles, and, if surrounding communities were also hit, that was to be accepted; then, as the war progressed, it became common for the combatants simply to attack civilians as part of military strategy.

By the time the 1980s rolled around, we were placing our entire faith in a weapon whose *fundamental target was the civilian population*.

A nuclear war is aimed at people, no matter how often military men like to say, “No, we only aim to hit other missiles.”

One of the first statistics I saw as president was one of the most sobering and startling I’d ever heard. I’ll never forget it:

The Pentagon said at least 150 million American lives would be lost in a nuclear war with the Soviet Union—even if we “won.”

For Americans who survived such a war, I couldn’t imagine what life would be like. The planet would be so poisoned the “survivors” would have no place to live.

Even if a nuclear war did not mean the extinction of mankind, it would certainly mean the end of civilization as we knew it.

No one could “win” a nuclear war. Yet as long as nuclear weapons were in existence, there would always be risks they would be used, and once the first nuclear weapon was unleashed, who knew where it would end?

My dream, then, became a world free of nuclear weapons.

Some of my advisors, including a number at the Pentagon, did not share this dream. They couldn’t conceive of it. They said a nuclear-free world was unattainable and it would be dangerous for us even if it were possible; some even